Asking questions or admitting confusion

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D07-S1–S6

Contents

Asking questions or admitting confusion 1
1. Explain when and how students can ask 1
2. Ask focused questions about uncertainty 1
3. Provide a way to ask without speaking publicly 2
4. Give students language for requesting clarification 2
5. Respond constructively when students reveal confusion 3
6. Build in opportunities to identify what remains unclear 3
Supporting sources 4

Students may be unsure how to ask a question, lack the English to explain their difficulty, or feel uncomfortable revealing confusion publicly. Make clarification a routine part of learning and provide several ways to seek it.

1. Explain when and how students can ask

Tell students how questions will be handled in your classes. Explain when they can interrupt, when you will pause for questions, and how they can contact you afterwards.

Example — Engineering

"If a step in a calculation is unclear, raise your hand so we can check it before continuing. I'll also pause after each worked example. You can submit a written question at the end."

Demonstrate the process during an early lesson and remind students when introducing a new type of activity.

For questions outside class, explain where to send them and when students can expect a response.

2. Ask focused questions about uncertainty

Invite questions about a particular part of the content. Give students time to look back at their notes and identify what they need clarified.

Example — Accounting

"Look back at how we classified those transactions. What would you like clarified about the difference between an asset and an expense?"

Pause before continuing. If nobody responds, use a short example to check understanding: "How would you classify this transaction, and why?"

Silence alone does not establish whether students understand.

3. Provide a way to ask without speaking publicly

Choose a written route that you can manage consistently, such as question slips or an anonymous online form.

How to do it

1. Explain where students should submit questions.
2. State whether submissions are anonymous.
3. Tell students when you will answer.
4. Address common questions without identifying individuals.

Example — Public health

"Before leaving, submit one point you would like explained further. You do not need to include your name. I'll address the common questions at the start of our next class."

For anonymous submissions, make answers available to everyone, since you cannot reply individually.

4. Give students language for requesting clarification

Display a few short phrases students can use. Model how to complete them with content from your subject.

What the student needs	Possible wording
Hear something again	"Could you repeat the last point?"
Identify an unclear term	"What does … mean here?"
Explain where understanding stops	"I understand …, but I'm not clear about …"
Request an example	"Could you show another example of …?"
Check an interpretation	"Do you mean that …?"

Example — Economics

"I understand that prices increased, but I'm not clear about why purchasing power fell."

Show how this identifies a specific point you can explain. Students can use their own wording or point to a slide, diagram or calculation if they cannot yet express the question fully.

5. Respond constructively when students reveal confusion

Listen to the question and establish which part needs clarification. Acknowledge it without judging the student, then try a different explanation, representation or example.

Example — Nursing
Student: "I don't understand the difference between a sign and a symptom."

Teacher: "Let's separate those terms. A sign is something observable or measurable, such as a raised temperature. A symptom is something the patient experiences and reports, such as nausea."

Then check through a small application: "A patient reports feeling dizzy. Which category does that fit, and why?"

Avoid relying only on "Do you understand now?" If uncertainty remains, identify the next point to work through.

6. Build in opportunities to identify what remains unclear

At selected stopping points, ask everyone to reflect on their understanding. Use a brief prompt rather than waiting for students to volunteer a question.

Possible prompts

- "Which step would you like us to revisit?"
- "What can you explain now, and what still needs clarification?"
- "Write one question about how this applies to the case."

Students can state that nothing is currently unclear; they do not need to invent a difficulty.

Example — Environmental science

"Write one difference between mitigation and adaptation, with an example of each. Add a question if any part remains unclear."

Review the responses and decide whether to clarify immediately, revisit the topic next class or provide individual support. Tell students how their responses informed your next step:

"Several responses showed uncertainty about adaptation, so we'll work through another example."

A short routine to try

At the end of one substantial explanation:

1. Give students a minute to review their notes.
2. Invite a question about a specific point.
3. Offer a written option.
4. Clarify common difficulties.
5. Use a short application to check understanding.

Supporting sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Discussions*.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Teaching support*.

University of Nebraska–Lincoln, Graduate Studies. (n.d.). *Muddiest point*.

University of Waterloo, Centre for Teaching Excellence. (n.d.). *Question strategies*.